

No Precedent (640 words)

On a solemn June morning, I watched the Island County Superior Court jury convict a seventeen-year-old boy of manslaughter. He was with friends, and when one didn't respond to his question, he took out his gun and fired.

The jury stared at him with stone-cold eyes as he fidgeted at the defense table. When he received a guilty verdict and an eight-year sentence, he broke down. As his cries brought me to tears, I thought about how these kids could've been my peers.

How did our system's guardrails to protect us adolescents fail so miserably? Why were we patching the cracks with criminal justice instead of restoring the broken foundation underneath with preventative programs?

I turned to the case's defense attorney and my internship mentor, Craig, for answers.

He brought me to the towering file cabinets, where I spent the summer poring over the last four years of youth-related court cases in Island County. At the surface level, kids were involved in repeated drug and violence offenses, some part of gangs, others isolated. Inspired by Craig, who met his clients in-person, I emailed a few of these past respondents, hoping to understand their experiences.

A few weeks later, I met Emerson. I greeted her with a warm smile, but she didn't reciprocate. The first five minutes felt like an eternity—as if my words were sucked into the void of her pale green eyes. I got no more than two words at a time. Resorting to my fail-proof method of breaking the ice, I started cracking jokes. With the first few jokes, I got a few awkward stares, but soon enough, she was opening up and even made a few jabs too.

Her story was poignant: a military child on her fourth move in three years. As soon as she began to feel "at home," her family had packed their bags for the next move. Left with no sense of community, she turned to the only thing that put her reliably at ease: drugs. At just sixteen, she had a criminal record and no hope for her future.

This stood in stark contrast to what I'd experienced during my three years as a mentor at King County Youth Court. There, peers intervened in structured settings; here, kids faced unforgiving repercussions in a system that wasn't designed for them. I began to believe Island County youth needed a psychologically safe space to learn from their mistakes and earn a second chance.

So I set out to build Island County's first youth court.

For months, administrators tore apart my proposals, but I doubled down and met with my constituents: the youth. I presented to Coupeville High School's National Honor Society and spent two days with Oak Harbor High School's Navy Junior R.O.T.C., teaching and learning alongside over 200 cadets to understand their lives. One aspiring JAG officer saw Youth Court as a path to skills his school couldn't offer. Another, diagnosed with type 1 diabetes and no longer eligible for military service, rediscovered hope in pursuing law. What I designed as a diversion program also created otherwise nonexistent career-readiness opportunities.

Their aspirations made the hurdles worth fighting through.

When court administrators flagged privacy concerns and demanded strict anonymization, I searched all 13 Washington Youth Court manifestos but found no precedent. I worked closely with Island County judges and legislators to create a training system for student volunteers using fictional cases before progressing to real ones, closing the final gap.

Today, forty-five students are serving in Island County's first Youth Court.

Yet, I keep thinking about Emerson. My diversion program will give youth a second chance, a space to be held accountable for their actions. But I still don't know whether any courtroom can compensate for what's lost when a family relocates, or if justice systems are even equipped to address that kind of instability.